

## HAPPY 100TH WEEK OF AUTHORS' ANARCHY!!!! :D



### INTRODUCTION

This academic year has been rough in the sense that it's been better. Being better is a beast of its own to reckon with... a change of state? In high school I had much less free time, but I put out *so* much! I was sick and cold and I wrote in a corner, in a cage, in a wire mother sucking at a wire grandmother. I find myself now at some sort of fault, or triple point, where everything hangs free and I'm not sure how to yank one thing without sending them all tumbling down. What now? What of the pretty green fields and the relatively quiet hours after work? Drip, drip, drip.

I've spent so much time staring at the wall, worrying about the hobbies/people/skies I pursue, how they grow slippery. It doesn't feel right to argue that I have breadth. The word is tuned to the key of betrayal.

Aimlessness aired out (we can't *all* mope forever), here are a few shorts I've written recently!

### WIFE

The fish writhes in its sick-pit— eyes blown like glass, scales snatching the light to shoot rainbows, last bids at life, into our laps. It thinks, maybe, that they are the sponsors of its misery— that whenever they speak, they are asking how it would like to go.

Over there, by the smoked light and the algae nets?

Closer, sundried on the rocks?

Further, sliced clean in half by a propeller?

It flips to one side, then the other, then bobs upside down for quite some time, buoyed by its pendulous stomach.

Ale-wife.

They cannot call it a woman, but they try anyway.

The thing permits pain well enough to be one; entrapment by way of algae, duck bill, rock, they all smooth out in the end. There isn't any good reason to fight such finality, and if heaven is certain, everything is certain.

Feeling down, they comfort the dying wife in whispers. They've seen themselves break, whimper like kittens, choke on their spit when the going gets tough. If mankind suffers, allkind does. No big deal, right?

But they fear too much to brush this off.

They are young and sunburnt, and have just learned that humanity can/will cry at itself in the water. Like criminals, their heads hang low; heavy. *Poor, poor fish*, they coo, almost too stunned (by nature, by heat, by the cruel rind and the empty pith of it all) to speak their condolences.

Tears salt the lake. They dump its shape offshore.  
As if fed, the sun beats harder yet.

### **NOT-FRIEND**

There are no such things as miracles under these stars  
You attest to one truth only: work,  
A fraying then a retwisting of the mind-body-soul,  
And if not that, a club and clout over the head (how else will they learn?)

You fall after fish in flight,  
Straining for something impossible, something burning  
Some lofty idea of success that, when attained, feels like...  
I wouldn't know

It takes muscle to reckon with *being* so much and being seen so little  
Life a constant fight as it is (as you so often tell me),  
Ruthlessness spices the tongue

*I watched them place bets on how far I could run,  
How many heads I could lob before I'd burn up, you once said,  
But look, now  
I am clean, and they are white in the gutter*

Looking through your eyes then, I thought to see this country's blood  
To salute your work very bashfully because, like most,  
Violence scared me  
Being born of it, even worse

But a quietness instead  
Slept there;

A basement with an orange lamp, blue-green-brown balconies overlooking [REDACTED], [REDACTED], [REDACTED]  
[REDACTED], an enormous tree in the village square  
Pigeons, doves, funeral rites— prayers too, Dog knows you needed those  
So much love throwing spanners in the world's self-righteous machinery

Impossible gentleness after famine, hands bent at my chest  
Ears pricked to hear the lub / dub of well-fed valves  
Proud to have grown such fierce little fruit

I can't imagine how you reckon with either side of yourself  
One hardened to survive, the other softened to do the same  
But there is little to be said about strength besides, well, "You are strong"

You are strong and tender and ruthless and merciful and  
I am always left wondering

### **ON THE SAME, 1**

You sit, acutely aware of place and time. Green paint peels at unionized speed down the walls. This disrepair speaks of permanence— this roaming mildew of truth. Since forever, ever, and most ever, this place has held court in ivied heads to lord over the brighter things.

There is a quiet uneasiness about your conversation.  
Too tired to tug at strings, you remain silent, engendering an odd sort of look, speak, look away, speak less— algorithmic patterning, zeroes and ones in the eye.

The body opposite from you leans ahead, craning her neck. Sunbeams stretch from the front door to her forehead, and as she dons what could only be called a program, "I love your hair" flies past. She half-expects it to materialize and lend some life to the disassembled thing swirling her cup, but nothing happens.

You'd decided this morning to wear a sundress. Your breasts are sticking to the fabric, pendulous and small as teardrops, and she hasn't spoken a word of it, for better or worse. More than criticism, you fear that she will come down on you like a hawk, rib you for your silence of late, and claim offense — which couldn't ever be the case. Wouldn't ever.

Small, easy bits (the weather, the bitter coffee, the stain on your plate); these come and go with practiced speed instead. She is pretty, and she has always been pretty, and she has always been a small, easy word. Syllables round at her command.

Sometimes your eyes will drift from the face, which falls out of focus, to the space right behind it. You imagine which painting she blocks with her head— that oppressive museum bust of a head— and how important it must be, how special to your discussion— and why the lacklustre, half-admitted loss of this whole thing solely rests on the fact that it has been hidden— because nobody really cares about pharmaceutical company internships. Nobody cares about waltzing searches for employment. Or halting two-steps over a bridge. Three years before, or four, or five, the sky was hale and healthy. You were two bodies crammed together like eggs in a carton. Clouds ate the moon whole, fish-scaling about the edges, and this meant the world opened up to you entirely. Ritually.

You are stricken by the sense that you've not missed but already published a seminal paper, and your best conference days have fallen away.

Right, like *look* at her.

She speaks in tongues still, and adjusts her bag— body half-poised to leave.

How good it feels to walk down these streets, she says then and again, just barely grazing fortune, and you dig— oh, you try— to find something of note to say, like “I’m glad you’re well”, but why? To what end?

This is a hundredth demonstration of your prize-winning assay. It gets a laugh out of her when you hearken back, remember when...

Throw the line and sinker. Remember when I jumped off the, remember when I wrote that exam after, remember when we came late to, remember when someone caught us?

So follow your attempts at panning for more than perfunctory responses. You pry skin from flesh, dig like a loveless historian for something that may have never been at all, and eventually you give up.

Despite all attempts to break the a posteriori ice between science and soul, some irrational part of the mind holds on. Sure enough, pain is a matter of circuitry, and when certain buttons are blipped you'll fall right flat — how much you loved, lived, and let die matters little— but pain, pain, pain is a mythical word.

The body opposite you shines like oil. She speaks benevolently and takes nothing personally, and even the expectant little thing in her eyes is metered. Maybe she was never loud and angry, and maybe she'd never expected to come back, seeing you squirming like so, and *maybe* it made her uncomfortable that a spandrel lived still. If not for the sweat upon your back, you might very well be gone.

And you! Oh, you've stumbled upon some terrible alien ground... face and form so familiar, voice so stilted. Thinking of her as a character, then thinking of yourself as cardboard, then thinking of God as an onlooker, waiting for you to run— none of these help very much. Your body is older, and this is why you drip from your sundress.

Your back aches. She has grown into her skin quite squarely, but flits about like a ghost while you splay yourself over the table, still offering your stories, memories, grasping at straws.

One last bit for the road:

Back in school, you'd always hated euthanizing the knockout mice. Nights before your first kill, a part of you knew it was coming. You woke in a puddle around 3:00 AM, having just dreamt of the most adorable, big-eared baby you'd ever gotten the pleasure of testing. After data collection, you *begged* to take it home—

But rules are rules.

You snapped its neck instead.

## ON THE SAME, 2

The grass was stringy and the robins on the fences stumbled a-caterwauling, drunk with summer fever. If any illness at all came up, or was to come up, it could only be puerile, trivial—a quick cold to remind them of their hollow bones and growing pains and the sheer enormity of the moment, even for less than one.

You told me about your dream very haltingly. Against all rhyme and reason, you'd dreamt of how to survive without today—the hot breeze passing through the earth like breath through a pan flute; the arm-wrestled mallets on searing steel drums; the old elementary school, boards slapped over the window with just enough wiggle room for your hands. There was another way to make it through, but the prospect of trying anything better seemed to terrify you. An impossible upgrade.

At the edge of the field, an older man's dog ran free.

It looked as if the dog would run off the planet.

Poets are poets because they haven't got time for novels, you said, and soon we won't have the time. Which is the real issue. I don't want to be scrawling down every little thing that I must squeeze beauty from, otherwise my life will be a play-by-play and my suffering will be sport.

Isn't your suffering sport already, I started to ask, but stopped myself. Because the day was young, soft around the edges, and would be much better spent happily.

## PEBBLY SHORE

imagine recouping the sun  
counting each lake gnat in the whorl of your eye throwing wicker-baskets over that delicate webbing  
letting the moment mythologize in the dark between checkerboard spots  
there are tales to be told of  
moments spent too idle too dangerously idle ripe for the caution-telling  
but let's rather believe (for now at least lost in most regards soul siphoned into whichever point of the body finds another's) that this is one of the rare good fables  
some paean to proles saying singing leaping such words like  
love love love  
how tired the arms how worked the legs  
what matters of form when form's undone  
we hate it so badly make love so madly and  
fie on magic write only indignity

## MONDAY

What a pretty<sup>1</sup> little thing.

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<sup>1</sup> *A soggy shape with nubs for arms, stumps for legs, empty-headed (save for the puerile joy of simpleness) with enough bends to conquer and a frame barren enough to remain unclaimed—hips streaming through cornfields, producing nothing for no one, stale and steamed when touch does not rain upon her. She desires saving, but her salvation would hoard gifts much better suited to serious persons; thus she must only **want** in some base, carnal sense. She does not understand death; the closest thing is sex.*